

What does it mean to believe in fate? To believe in fate is to believe that there are now truths about all of the future actions that any of us will undertake.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to freedom that comes from fate.

So, for example, if fate is real then it is already true now whether you will or won't get married -- and if you will, it is true now that you will marry a certain person, on a certain date, at a certain time. Or, to pick a more grim example, there is already a truth about the exact moment you will die, and how.

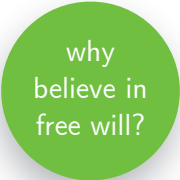
We might imagine that all of the facts about your life — past, present, and future — are written down in a dusty book in a library somewhere. Of course, there is no such book. But, if fate is real, then there could be. The truths are all there, whether or not they have been written down.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

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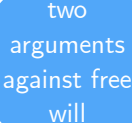
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We'll shortly consider some ways of

for fatalsn.

first let's think about how Edwards'

argument might be related to an argument

responding to Edwards' argument. But

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

Suppose that someone did not believe in

similar to Edwards' argument?

actions. Could they give an argument

there were truths about all our future

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

God only shows up in premises (2) and

our future actions.

with reference to the being of truth about

(5) Let's look at what happens if we



2* In the past, there were truths about

1. We have no direct facts.

God knows that in the future I will

3 We have not at the fact that

all of our activities.

that if it is true that I will perform

perform a certain action (1,2)

will perform various actions.

then we have the choice about q.

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

0 We have achieved what we



(3, 4, 5)

acaioid.

some action, then I will prefer that

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

5* We have noticed that the fact

The fatalist argument

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predict.

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

either.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

things as fate, then there is no free will.

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

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